Bharat

Rooted in Heritage, Inspired for the Future

Ancient Wisdom for Modern Excellence

Learn.
Practise.
Serve.
Grow.



Your year begins Sunday 17 January 2027

Come every third Sunday · 9:30 am · bring your family

Twelve months from the Vedas to the Buddha · a handbook for everyone

WE BEGIN EVERY GATHERING TOGETHER

ॐ सह नाववतु । सह नौ भुनक्तु ।
सह वीर्यं करवावहै ।
तेजस्वि नावधीतमस्तु मा विद्विषावहै ।
ॐ शान्तिः शान्तिः शान्तिः ॥

Oṁ saha nāvavatu, saha nau bhunaktu, saha vīryaṁ karavāvahai, tejasvi nāv adhītam astu, mā vidviṣāvahai. Oṁ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ śāntiḥ.

May we be protected together, nourished together. May we work together with energy. May our learning be bright. May we never be hostile to one another. Peace, peace, peace.

Katha and Taittiriya Upanishads (shanti mantra)

WELCOME

A gurukul in our own neighbourhood

Bharat: Rooted in Heritage, Inspired for the Future brings India's timeless wisdom to every family in [LOCALITY]. On the third Sunday of each month in 2027, children, youth, parents, working people, elders and civic leaders gather for one morning of learning, practice and seva.

We follow India's wisdom in the order it unfolded through history, from the Vedas to the Buddha, with the Ramayana and the Mahabharata at the heart of the year.

No fees. No sponsors. Only seva.

Everything is run by volunteers from our neighbourhood. Nobody is paid and nothing is sold. Every topic is presented by two or three volunteers, and a small Seva Kosh box meets the cost of printing and children's materials.

How to use this booklet

- Bring it to every gathering and collect a stamp on your Sadhana page.
- Read the month's pages at home before and after the gathering.
- Tick off each day of the month's home practice (*sankalp*).
- Talk about the month's life question at the dinner table.

WHY WE GATHER

Grow yourself. Grow together.

Our ancestors saw development as a chain. A better person makes a better family, a stronger community and a greater nation.

Vyakti The individual
Focus, discipline, calm, character

↓

Parivar The family
Respect, time together, shared values

↓

Samaj The community
Seva, harmony, neighbours who care

↓

Rashtra The nation
Pride, responsibility, Viksit Bharat 2047

वसुधैव कुटुम्बकम्

Vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam: the whole world is one family. Maha Upanishad 6.71–72

WHAT WE LEARN

Four pillars of Bharatiya management

Every month's teaching is seen through the same four lenses, so the year builds into one complete way of living and leading.

Wisdom *(Jñāna)*
Who am I, and what is worth pursuing?
From: Vedas, Upanishads, Kathopanishad, the Buddha

Life management *(Swadharma)*
Discipline, balance, focus and calm
From: Yoga, Pranayama, Bhagavad Gita

Human management *(Sambandha)*
Family, respect, empathy and service
From: Ramayana, Srimad Bhagavatam

Complete management *(Rājadharma)*
Ethical leadership of teams and communities
From: Mahabharata, the assemblies of the Buddha's time

A GURUKUL WITH A MODERN TOUCH

One Sunday morning

9:30	**Deep prajwalan** Invited delegates open the gathering, lighting the lamp with a child and an elder
9:45	**Pravachan** Two or three volunteers present the topic together: the story, the verses, and what it means today
10:30	**Vishram** A short break
10:45	**Shishya sabha** Four learning circles with activities and games
11:30	**Quiz** A quick quiz on the day's topic for everyone
11:45	**Prashnottari** Life's question from the epics; open questions, children first
12:10	**Sanskriti** Bhajan, dance or skit
12:25	**Sankalp and certificates** The month's home practice, and a certificate for everyone who took part

Bal Gurukul
children 8–14

Yuva Sabha
youth and families

Karma Sabha
professionals and civic leaders

Vriddha Sabha
elders

Invited delegates open each gathering, every topic is presented by two or three volunteers, and everyone who takes part receives a certificate at the end of the day.

THE JOURNEY, OLDEST FIRST

From the Vedas to the Buddha

Month	Topic	Festival link
Jan	**The Vedas** The roots of Bharat	Makar Sankranti
Feb	**Vedic sciences** Knowledge born from the Vedas	Vasant Panchami
Mar	**Upanishads** Knowing yourself	Holi
Apr	**Kathopanishad** Nachiketa and mastering the mind	Ram Navami
May	**Dhyana and Pranayama** Calm in every storm	Buddha Purnima
Jun	**Yoga** Strong body, steady mind, good conduct	International Day of Yoga (21 June)
Jul	**Ramayana** Character, family and keeping your word	Guru Purnima
Aug	**Mahabharata** Right action in conflict	Independence Day · Raksha Bandhan
Sep	**Bhagavad Gita** Courage, duty and clear decisions	Ganesh Chaturthi
Oct	**Srimad Bhagavatam** Devotion, courage and joy in service	Navaratri · Sharad Purnima
Nov	**India in the Buddha's time** An age of questions and assemblies	Kartik Purnima
Dec	**Gautama Buddha** The middle way and a compassionate mind	Annual finale

Every third Sunday, 9:30 am to 12:30 pm, at [VENUE]. Festival links are seasonal; check the local panchang.

JANUARY · MAKAR SANKRANTI

01 The Vedas

The roots of Bharat

Sunday 17 January 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

The Vedas are India's oldest texts. They teach that truth is one, that we must live in harmony with nature, and that people must walk and decide together.

Tradition holds the Vedas to be eternal (apauruṣeya); most scholars date the Rigveda to about 1500–1200 BCE.

Key verses

Tat savitur vareṇyaṁ bhargo devasya dhīmahi, dhiyo yo naḥ pracodayāt
Rigveda 3.62.10 (Gayatri)
We meditate on the radiant light of the divine sun; may it inspire our minds.

Ekaṁ sad viprā bahudhā vadanti
Rigveda 1.164.46
Truth is one; the wise call it by many names.

Saṁ gacchadhvaṁ saṁ vadadhvaṁ saṁ vo manāṁsi jānatām
Rigveda 10.191.2
Walk together, speak together, let your minds be in harmony.

Mātā bhūmiḥ putro ahaṁ pṛthivyāḥ
Atharvaveda 12.1.12
The earth is my mother; I am her child.

QUIZ CORNER

1. How many Vedas are there? (A) Two (B) Three (C) Four (D) Six

2. Which Veda is called the root of Indian music? (A) Rigveda (B) Samaveda (C) Yajurveda (D) Atharvaveda

3. "Ekaṁ sad viprā bahudhā vadanti" means... (A) Truth is one; the wise call it by many names (B) Walk together, speak together (C) The earth is my mother (D) Arise and awake

Answers: 1 C, 2 B, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- The four Vedas: Rig (hymns), Sama (melodies, the root of Indian music), Yajur (ritual) and Atharva (daily life and healing).
- Women seers such as Ghosha, Apala and Lopamudra composed Vedic hymns.
- The Vedas were kept alive by memory for over 3,000 years; UNESCO recognises Vedic chanting as world heritage.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Learn the Gayatri with a clapping rhythm; Surya Namaskar
Yuva Sabha	A memory game in the Vedic krama style
Karma Sabha	A meeting where everyone speaks before anyone decides
Vriddha Sabha	Prayers we learnt by heart as children
Games	Mantra relay · Sun salutation freeze

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

When plans collapse

Told he is to be exiled instead of crowned, Rama stays calm and still bows to his father and to Kaikeyi.

Ramayana, Ayodhya Kanda 18

Sankalp for 30 days: Greet the rising sun each morning and sit in silence for three minutes.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

FEBRUARY · VASANT PANCHAMI

02 Vedic sciences

Knowledge born from the Vedas

Sunday 21 February 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

To understand the Vedas, our ancestors built sciences of sound, grammar, mathematics, astronomy, health and building. Learning and devotion were never separate.

The popular "Vedic Maths" speed tricks come from a 20th-century book by Swami Bharati Krishna Tirtha, not from the Vedas themselves.

Key verses

Sarasvati namastubhyaṁ varade kāmarūpiṇi, vidyārambhaṁ kariṣyāmi siddhir bhavatu me sadā

Traditional prayer before study

Salutations to Saraswati; as I begin to learn, may I always succeed.

Yathā śikhā mayūrāṇāṁ nāgānāṁ maṇayo yathā, tadvad vedāṅga-śāstrāṇāṁ gaṇitaṁ mūrdhani sthitam

Vedanga Jyotisha

As the crest on the peacock and the jewel on the cobra, so mathematics stands at the head of the sciences.

Samadoṣaḥ samāgniśca samadhātu malakriyaḥ, prasannātmendriyamanaḥ svastha ityabhidhīyate

Sushruta Samhita, Sutrasthana

Health is balance of body and digestion, with a happy self, senses and mind.

QUIZ CORNER

1. The Shulba Sutras give rules for building... (A) Fire altars (B) Ships (C) Roads (D) Forts
2. How many Vedangas are there? (A) Four (B) Six (C) Eight (D) Twelve
3. Which Upaveda is about health? (A) Ayurveda (B) Dhanurveda (C) Gandharvaveda (D) Sthapatyaveda

Answers: 1 A, 2 B, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- The six Vedangas: phonetics, grammar, metre, meaning of words, astronomy and ritual.
- The Shulba Sutras give rope-and-peg geometry for building altars, including the relationship now called Pythagoras' theorem.
- Ayurveda teaches health as balance: daily routine (dinacharya), food and sleep.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Rope geometry and a Saraswati vandana
Yuva Sabha	Mental-maths games and a science quiz
Karma Sabha	Design a realistic daily routine for working life
Vriddha Sabha	Household knowledge of food and seasons
Games	Rope geometry challenge · Vedanga match

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Laziness and putting things off

Vidura names six faults that hold a person back: too much sleep, drowsiness, fear, anger, laziness and delay.

Mahabharata, Udyoga Parva (Vidura Niti), CE 5.33.66

Sankalp for 30 days: Ten minutes of new learning every day, and one fixed time to sleep and wake.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

MARCH · HOLI

03 Upanishads

Knowing yourself

Sunday 21 March 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

The Upanishads turn the search inward. They ask "Who am I?" and answer that the same divine self lives in every being.

Key verses

Asato mā sad gamaya, tamaso mā jyotir gamaya, mṛtyor mā amṛtaṁ gamaya
Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 1.3.28
Lead me from untruth to truth, from darkness to light, from death to immortality.

Tat tvam asi
Chandogya Upanishad 6.8.7
You are that.

Mātṛdevo bhava, pitṛdevo bhava, ācāryadevo bhava, atithidevo bhava
Taittiriya Upanishad 1.11.2
Treat mother, father, teacher and guest as divine.

Satyam eva jayate
Mundaka Upanishad 3.1.6
Truth alone triumphs. (India's national motto.)

QUIZ CORNER

1. "Tat tvam asi" (you are that) comes from which Upanishad? (A) Chandogya (B) Katha (C) Isha (D) Mundaka

2. India's national motto "Satyameva jayate" comes from... (A) Mundaka Upanishad (B) Rigveda (C) Bhagavad Gita (D) Ramayana

3. In the salt story, the self is like salt in water because it is... (A) Present everywhere though unseen (B) Only in the heart (C) Only in the sky (D) Only in books

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Shvetaketu and the salt: unseen in water, yet present in every sip, like the self in all things (Chandogya 6.13).
- Satyakama Jabala tells his teacher the plain truth about his birth and is accepted for his honesty (Chandogya 4.4).
- At the end of study, the teacher says: “Speak the truth, follow dharma.” (Taittiriya 1.11.1)

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	The salt-in-water experiment
Yuva Sabha	Write “I am…” ten times, then cross out every label
Karma Sabha	Honesty at work when it costs you
Vriddha Sabha	How atithi devo bhava was lived at home
Games	The salt mystery · Beyond the label

LIFE’S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

What real wealth is

The Yaksha asks Yudhishthira who is truly rich. The answer: one to whom joy and sorrow, past and future, are alike.

Mahabharata, Vana Parva (Yaksha Prashna), CE 3.297.62–64

Sankalp for 30 days: Five minutes of journalling each night: who am I beyond my roles today?

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY’S NOTES

APRIL · RAM NAVAMI

04 Kathopanishad

Nachiketa and mastering the mind

Sunday 18 April 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

A boy, Nachiketa, has the courage to ask Death itself about the meaning of life. His teacher shows that a trained mind, guided by a clear intellect, carries us to our goal.

Key verses

Ātmānaṁ rathinaṁ viddhi śarīraṁ ratham eva tu, buddhiṁ tu sārathiṁ viddhi manaḥ pragraham eva ca

Kathopanishad 1.3.3

The self is the rider, the body the chariot, the intellect the charioteer, the mind the reins.

Anyac chreyo 'nyad utaiva preyaḥ

Kathopanishad 1.2.1

The good is one thing, the pleasant another. The wise choose the good.

Uttiṣṭhata jāgrata prāpya varān nibodhata

Kathopanishad 1.3.14

Arise, awake, and learn from the wise. (Swami Vivekananda's call to youth.)

QUIZ CORNER

1. From whom did Nachiketa learn the secret of life? (A) Yama (B) Vishvamitra (C) Vasishtha (D) Indra

2. In the chariot image, the reins stand for... (A) The mind (B) The senses (C) The intellect (D) The body

3. The horses in the chariot image are... (A) The senses (B) The mind (C) The self (D) The road

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Nachiketa waits three days at Yama's door and refuses wealth and pleasure, asking only for true knowledge.
- The chariot: untrained horses (the senses) run wild unless the charioteer (intellect) holds the reins (mind).
- Shreyas over preyas: choose what is good in the long run over what is pleasant now.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Draw and label the chariot; a question box
Yuva Sabha	List your "horses" and one rein for each
Karma Sabha	Short-term targets versus long-term good
Vriddha Sabha	Discipline in our youth, without screens
Games	Chariot tug · Question box race

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Anger, pride and greed

The Yaksha teaches: give up pride and you are loved; give up anger and you do not grieve; give up greed and you are happy.

Mahabharata, Vana Parva (Yaksha Prashna), CE 3.297.57

Sankalp for 30 days: Ten screen-free minutes a day, and one family hour a week with all phones in a basket.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Stamp

OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

MAY · BUDDHA PURNIMA

05 Dhyana and Pranayama

Calm in every storm

Sunday 16 May 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

The sages found that when the breath is steady, the mind becomes steady. Breath and meditation are tools anyone can use, at any age.

Take care: no breath-holding for anyone with high blood pressure, heart conditions or pregnancy. Stop at any dizziness.

Key verses

Tāṁ yogam iti manyante sthirām indriya-dhāraṇām

Kathopanishad 2.3.11

The steady holding of the senses is called yoga: one of the earliest definitions.

Oṁ ity etad akṣaram idaṁ sarvam

Mandukya Upanishad 1

Om: this sound is all this.

Cale vāte calaṁ cittaṁ niścale niścalaṁ bhavet

Hatha Yoga Pradipika 2.2 (a later text recording older practice)

When the breath moves, the mind moves; when the breath is still, the mind is still.

QUIZ CORNER

1. Bhramari is also called... (A) Bee breath (B) Lion breath (C) Fire breath (D) Cooling breath

2. Anulom-vilom is... (A) Alternate-nostril breathing (B) Holding the breath (C) Fast breathing (D) Humming

3. The Kathopanishad calls the steady holding of the senses... (A) Yoga (B) Tapas (C) Seva (D) Bhakti

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Om chanting: three long Oms.
- Anulom-vilom (alternate-nostril breathing), five slow rounds.
- Bhramari (bee breath): a soft hum with ears closed; it calms children quickly.
- Simple dhyana: watch the breath for two minutes.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Bee breath and a stillness game
Yuva Sabha	A five-minute exam-calm routine
Karma Sabha	A three-minute desk meditation
Vriddha Sabha	Gentle pranayama on chairs
Games	Stillness statue · Bee-breath choir

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Forgiveness

Vidura tells the king: forgiveness alone is the highest peace (kṣamaikā śāntir uttamā).

Mahabharata, Udyoga Parva (Vidura Niti), CE 5.33.48

Sankalp for 30 days: Five minutes of slow breathing or silent sitting every morning.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

06 Yoga

Strong body, steady mind, good conduct

Sunday 20 June 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Yoga is an eight-step path that begins with how we treat others and ourselves, and ends in a still, clear mind.

Yoga's roots are in the Upanishads; Patanjali gathered the teaching into the Yoga Sutras, which scholars date to roughly the 2nd century BCE–4th century CE.

Key verses

Yogaś citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ

Yoga Sutra 1.2

Yoga is the stilling of the movements of the mind.

Sthira-sukham āsanam

Yoga Sutra 2.46

A posture should be steady and comfortable.

Yogaḥ karmasu kauśalam

Bhagavad Gita 2.50

Yoga is skill in action.

QUIZ CORNER

1. Yoga Sutra 1.2 defines yoga as... (A) Stilling the movements of the mind (B) Standing on one's head (C) A kind of exercise (D) Chanting mantras
2. How many limbs does Patanjali's yoga have? (A) Four (B) Six (C) Eight (D) Ten
3. Ahimsa (non-violence) is one of the... (A) Yamas (B) Niyamas (C) Asanas (D) Pranayamas

Answers: 1 A, 2 C, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Yamas (how we treat others): non-violence, truth, not stealing, self-restraint, not hoarding (Yoga Sutra 2.30).
- Niyamas (how we treat ourselves): cleanliness, contentment, discipline, self-study, surrender (Yoga Sutra 2.32).
- In 2014 the UN declared 21 June the International Day of Yoga, co-sponsored by 177 countries.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Animal asanas; five golden-rule cards
Yuva Sabha	Yoga for posture and screen fatigue
Karma Sabha	Desk yoga; the yamas as a code of work
Vriddha Sabha	Chair yoga
Games	Animal asana freeze · Yama-niyama sort

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Self-mastery at work

Vidura: the wise are not pulled from their purpose by anger, joy, pride or shame, and stay calm like a deep pool of the Ganga.

Mahabharata, Udyoga Parva (Vidura Niti), CE 5.33.17, 26

Sankalp for 30 days: Fifteen minutes of yoga daily, with three rounds of Surya Namaskar.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

JULY · GURU PURNIMA

07 Ramayana

Character, family and keeping your word

Sunday 18 July 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Character is built through small choices: keeping your word, respecting elders and serving without expecting reward.

We follow Valmiki's Ramayana (Gita Press numbering). Scenes such as the Lakshman Rekha and Shabari tasting the berries come from later retellings and are told as such.

Key verses

Rāmo vigrahavān dharmaḥ

Valmiki Ramayana, Aranya Kanda 37.13

Rama is dharma in human form, said even by his enemy Maricha.

Raghukula rīti sadā chali āī, prāna jāhu baru bachanu na jāī

Tulsidas, Ramcharitmanas, Ayodhya Kand

The way of Raghu's line: life may go, but a promise must not.

QUIZ CORNER

1. Who composed the original Ramayana? (A) Valmiki (B) Vyasa (C) Tulsidas (D) Kalidasa

2. What did Bharata place on the throne? (A) Rama's sandals (B) Rama's bow (C) A crown (D) A lamp

3. Who said "Rāmo vigrahavān dharmaḥ" (Rama is dharma embodied)? (A) Maricha (B) Hanuman (C) Lakshmana (D) Vibhishana

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Rama accepts fourteen years of exile to keep his father's word, without anger (Ayodhya Kanda 18).
- Bharata refuses the throne and rules as caretaker with Rama's sandals on it (Ayodhya Kanda 112).
- Sita puts a blade of grass between herself and Ravana and rebukes him (Sundara Kanda 21).
- Rama honours the aged Shabari and her service to her teachers (Aranya Kanda 74).

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Story theatre; paper padukas
Yuva Sabha	A promise that clashes with a new opportunity
Karma Sabha	Bharata as a model of trusteeship
Vriddha Sabha	The Ramayana as our grandparents told it
Games	Paduka relay · Who said it?

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Rivalry in the family

Bharata could have had the kingdom. Instead he places Rama's sandals on the throne and rules only in his name.

Ramayana, Ayodhya Kanda 112

Sankalp for 30 days: One act of service at home every day, done without being asked.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

08 Mahabharata

Right action in conflict

Sunday 15 August 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Life is full of grey situations. The Mahabharata shows how to choose rightly when every option has a cost, and what happens when greed and pride go unchecked.

We cite the BORI critical edition (CE). Some famous lines, such as the Yaksha's "greatest wonder", appear only in popular printed editions.

Key verses

Na tat parasya saṁdadhyāt pratikūlaṁ yad ātmanaḥ
Anushasana Parva, CE 13.114.8
Do not do to another what is hateful to yourself; this, in brief, is dharma.

Kṣamaikā śāntir uttamā
Udyoga Parva (Vidura Niti), CE 5.33.48
Forgiveness alone is the highest peace.

Yato dharmas tato jayaḥ
Udyoga Parva, CE 5.39.7
Where there is dharma, there is victory.

QUIZ CORNER

1. According to tradition, who composed the Mahabharata? (A) Vyasa (B) Valmiki (C) Kalidasa (D) Panini

2. In the Yaksha Prashna, whom does Yudhishthira ask to be revived? (A) Nakula (B) Bhima (C) Arjuna (D) Karna

3. "Kṣamaikā śāntir uttamā" (forgiveness is the highest peace) is the counsel of... (A) Vidura (B) Shakuni (C) Duryodhana (D) Drona

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- The dice game: Yudhishthira keeps staking as Shakuni taunts him (Sabha Parva, CE 2.58).
- Draupadi challenges the court: “Did he lose himself first, or me?” (CE 2.60.7–8)
- The Yaksha Prashna: wisdom, not force, saves the brothers (Vana Parva, CE 3.297).
- Vidura warns Dhritarashtra again and again; the king listens but does not act (Udyoga Parva).

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	“What would you do?” picture quiz
Yuva Sabha	A mock Yaksha Prashna
Karma Sabha	The one person who warned us: listening to Vidura
Vriddha Sabha	Elders as Bhishma: settling family disputes
Games	Yaksha’s riddles · Dilemma walk

LIFE’S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Speaking up against wrong

In a court full of elders, only Draupadi asks the question no one wants to answer: had Yudhishthira the right to stake her?

Mahabharata, Sabha Parva, CE 2.60.7–8

Sankalp for 30 days: Before any big decision, pause and consult one elder or trusted friend.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Stamp

OUR FAMILY’S NOTES

SEPTEMBER · GANESH CHATURTHI

09 Bhagavad Gita

Courage, duty and clear decisions

Sunday 19 September 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Do your duty fully and let go of anxiety about the result. A steady mind makes good decisions.

Tradition holds that Ganesha wrote down the Mahabharata, which contains the Gita, as Vyasa dictated it.

Key verses

Karmaṇy evādhikāras te mā phaleṣu kadācana
Bhagavad Gita 2.47
Your right is to action alone, never to its fruits.

Yogasthaḥ kuru karmāṇi … samatvaṁ yoga ucyate
Bhagavad Gita 2.48
Act while established in balance; evenness of mind is yoga.

Uddhared ātmanātmānaṁ nātmānam avasādayet
Bhagavad Gita 6.5
Lift yourself by your own effort; never pull yourself down.

Yad yad ācarati śreṣṭhas tat tad evetaro janaḥ
Bhagavad Gita 3.21
Whatever a great person does, others follow.

QUIZ CORNER

1. On which battlefield is the Gita spoken? (A) Kurukshetra (B) Lanka (C) Hastinapura (D) Ayodhya

2. Gita 2.47 says our right is to… (A) Action, not its fruits (B) The fruits alone (C) Rest (D) Wealth

3. A “sthitaprajña” is a person of… (A) Steady mind (B) Great wealth (C) Great strength (D) Many words

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Arjuna at Kurukshetra puts down his bow, overwhelmed by doubt; Krishna helps him see clearly, and Arjuna chooses to act.
- The sthitaprajña, the person of steady mind (2.54–2.72).
- Krishna, the greatest teacher, chose to serve as a charioteer.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Paper chariot craft with a Gita value on each wheel
Yuva Sabha	"My Kurukshetra": one hard choice, seen through 2.47
Karma Sabha	A manager pressed to cut an ethical corner
Vriddha Sabha	When the Gita guided our lives
Games	Chariot wheel craft · Verse completion relay

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Loyalty versus what is right

Karna turns down Krishna's offer out of loyalty to Duryodhana, yet admits: where there is dharma, there is victory.

Mahabharata, Udyoga Parva, CE 5.141.33

Sankalp for 30 days: Do one duty fully every day, without complaint and without worrying about the result.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

OCTOBER · NAVARATRI · SHARAD PURNIMA

10 Srimad Bhagavatam

Devotion, courage and joy in service

Sunday 17 October 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Devotion is open to everyone: a five-year-old, a poor friend or a whole village. Love and service, not status, bring us close to the divine.

We place the Bhagavatam here for the era of its story, Krishna's life; scholars date the text to about the 9th–10th century CE.

Key verses

Sa vai puṁsāṁ paro dharmo yato bhaktir adhokṣaje

Bhagavatam 1.2.6

The highest dharma is selfless, unbroken devotion.

Śravaṇaṁ kīrtanaṁ viṣṇoḥ smaraṇaṁ pāda-sevanam, arcanaṁ vandanaṁ dāsyaṁ sakhyam ātma-nivedanam

Bhagavatam 7.5.23

The nine forms of devotion, from listening and singing to friendship and self-offering.

QUIZ CORNER

1. What did Dhruva become? (A) The Pole Star (B) The moon (C) A river (D) A mountain
2. Who lifted Govardhan hill? (A) Krishna (B) Balarama (C) Hanuman (D) Bhima
3. What gift did Sudama bring Krishna? (A) Flattened rice (B) Gold (C) A flute (D) Flowers

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- Dhruva, aged five, does not give up and becomes the Pole Star (Canto 4).
- Prahlada holds to truth against his powerful father (Canto 7).
- Krishna lifts Govardhan, and every villager helps hold it up with a stick (Canto 10).
- Krishna runs barefoot to welcome his poor friend Sudama (Canto 10).

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Find the Pole Star; a paper Govardhan
Yuva Sabha	One act of service for someone who has less
Karma Sabha	Govardhan leadership: everyone holds a stick
Vriddha Sabha	Bhajans and Krishna stories of our region
Games	Find the Pole Star · Govardhan lift

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Courage at any age

The aged vulture Jatayu sees Ravana carrying Sita away and, though old and alone, stands up to fight him.

Ramayana, Aranya Kanda 51

Sankalp for 30 days: One act of selfless service each week, and one small personal goal kept daily, like Dhruva.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

NOVEMBER · KARTIK PURNIMA

11 India in the Buddha's time

An age of questions and assemblies

Sunday 21 November 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Around the 6th–5th century BCE, India was full of new cities, trade and bold thinkers. Kingdoms and republics debated and governed through assemblies.

Key verses

Yāvakīvañca, ānanda, vajjī abhiṇhaṁ sannipātā … vuddhiyeva pāṭikaṅkhā, no parihāni

Mahaparinibbana Sutta (Digha Nikaya 16)

As long as the Vajjis meet often and in large numbers, they will prosper, not decline.

Parasparopagraho jīvānām

Tattvartha Sutra 5.21 (Jain)

All living beings support one another.

QUIZ CORNER

1. How many Mahajanapadas were there? (A) Eight (B) Twelve (C) Sixteen (D) Twenty

2. The Vajjis of Vaishali were governed by… (A) An assembly (B) A single emperor (C) A foreign ruler (D) Priests alone

3. Mahavira taught above all… (A) Ahimsa (non-violence) (B) Conquest (C) Trade (D) Astronomy

Answers: 1 C, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- The sixteen Mahajanapadas: Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, Avanti, the Vajjis and more.
- The Buddha's seven conditions for a community's welfare: meet often, in harmony; keep good laws; respect elders; protect women; honour shrines; support the wise.
- Mahavira taught ahimsa and that truth has many sides (anekāntavāda).

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	Colour a map of the Mahajanapadas
Yuva Sabha	A mock assembly with voting tokens
Karma Sabha	The seven conditions as a health check for our ward
Vriddha Sabha	Local history of our area
Games	Mahajanapada map puzzle · Token vote

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Favouring your own

Dhritarashtra knows where dharma lies, yet cannot bring himself to give up his son Duryodhana.

Mahabharata, Udyoga Parva, CE 5.39.7

Sankalp for 30 days: Learn one story of our region's history and tell it at home; join one residents' or family meeting.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

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OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

DECEMBER · ANNUAL FINALE

12 Gautama Buddha

The middle way and a compassionate mind

Sunday 19 December 2027 · 9:30 am

Opening: an ambassador or invited delegate (to be announced) · **Presented by:** 2–3 volunteers (the story · the verses · today)

Siddhartha left comfort to understand suffering and found the middle way. His message of a trained mind, right action and compassion is part of India's shared heritage.

Scholars place the Buddha's life around the 5th century BCE; older estimates say the 6th.

Key verses

Manopubbaṅgamā dhammā manoseṭṭhā manomayā
Dhammapada 1
Mind comes first; all things are shaped by the mind.

Na hi verena verāni sammantīdha kudācanaṁ, averena ca sammanti esa dhammo sanantano
Dhammapada 5
Hatred never ends through hatred, only through love. This is an eternal law.

Attadīpā viharatha
Mahaparinibbana Sutta
Be a lamp unto yourselves.

QUIZ CORNER

1. Where did the Buddha attain enlightenment? (A) Bodh Gaya (B) Sarnath (C) Lumbini (D) Kushinagar

2. Where did the Buddha give his first teaching? (A) Sarnath (B) Rajgir (C) Vaishali (D) Shravasti

3. The Dharma Chakra on India's flag comes from the lion capital at... (A) Sarnath (B) Delhi (C) Ujjain (D) Mathura

Answers: 1 A, 2 A, 3 A · more games and the full quiz on the website

What we will learn

- His life: Lumbini, Bodh Gaya, the first teaching at Sarnath, Kushinagar.
- The Four Noble Truths and the Noble Eightfold Path.
- The Kalama Sutta: test a teaching for yourself before you accept it.
- Our flag's Dharma Chakra and our national emblem come from Sarnath.

In the circles

Bal Gurukul	The insult that was not accepted; a paper lotus
Yuva Sabha	Check three viral claims before forwarding
Karma Sabha	Right speech and right livelihood at work
Vriddha Sabha	Kisa Gotami: change, loss and acceptance
Games	The gift not accepted · Kalama check

LIFE'S QUESTION, FROM THE EPICS

Second chances

Rama's advisers doubt Vibhishana, but Rama gives him refuge: shelter for anyone who asks, even Ravana himself.

Ramayana, Yuddha Kanda 18.33

Sankalp for 30 days: Two minutes of loving-kindness each night, and our family's pledge for 2028 on the wall at home.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30

Stamp

OUR FAMILY'S NOTES

ANSWERED BY THE RAMAYANA AND MAHABHARATA

Life's questions, answered by our heritage

Life question	Episode	Where
Staying calm when plans collapse	Rama hears of his exile and stays calm	Ramayana, Ayodhya 18
Anger, pride, desire, greed	The Yaksha's teaching to Yudhishthira	MBh Vana, CE 3.297.57
Hard choices and fairness	Yudhishthira chooses Nakula so both mothers keep a son	MBh Vana, CE 3.297.55, 65–74
What real wealth is	Truly rich is one to whom joy and sorrow are alike	MBh Vana, CE 3.297.62–64
Sibling rivalry and power	Bharata rules with Rama's sandals	Ramayana, Ayodhya 112
Keeping promises	Rama keeps his father's word; Bharata vows to wait	Ramayana, Ayodhya 112
Friendship and resentment	Drupada turns away his childhood friend Drona	MBh Adi, CE 1.121
Courage at any age	Old Jatayu fights Ravana	Ramayana, Aranya 51
Loyalty versus right	Karna: where there is dharma, there is victory	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.141.33
Favouring your own child	Dhritarashtra cannot give up Duryodhana	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.39.7
Self-mastery at work	Vidura on the qualities of the wise	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.33.17, 26
Laziness and delay	Vidura's six faults	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.33.66
Forgiveness	Forgiveness alone is the highest peace	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.33.48

Life question	Episode	Where
Keeping counsel	The wise act first; plans are known once done	MBh Udyoga, CE 5.33.18
Envy and talent	Ekalavya and his thumb	MBh Adi, CE 1.123
Speaking up against wrong	Draupadi's question in the court	MBh Sabha, CE 2.60.7–8
When dharma seems not to protect	Draupadi's challenge to Yudhishthira	MBh Vana, CE 3.31.7
Greed and compulsion	The dice game	MBh Sabha, CE 2.58
Dignity and courage of women	Sita's blade of grass	Ramayana, Sundara 21
Heeding good advice	Maricha warns Ravana	Ramayana, Aranya 37.13
Second chances	Refuge for Vibhishana	Ramayana, Yuddha 18.33
Grace in victory	Full rites for Ravana	Ramayana, Yuddha 109
Respecting elders	Rama honours Shabari	Ramayana, Aranya 74
Empathy	Do not do to another what hurts you	MBh Anushasana, CE 13.114.8
Ethics in any job	The righteous butcher's teaching	MBh Vana, CE 3.198.69

Ramayana references follow Valmiki (Gita Press sarga numbers). Mahabharata references follow the BORI critical edition (CE chapter.verse); popular translations number chapters differently.

TELLING STORIES TRUTHFULLY

Every story, with its source

Our epics are living traditions, retold for over 2,000 years. We tell every story, and we say where it comes from.

Much-loved story or line	Where it comes from
The Lakshman Rekha	Not in Valmiki; from later tradition, including Tulsidas
Shabari tasting the berries	Later devotional retellings; in Valmiki she offers fruits she gathered
The squirrel at Rama Setu	Folk and regional tradition
Janani janmabhūmiś ca svargād api garīyasī	Not in the critical edition of the Ramayana; a later addition
Ahiṁsā paramo dharmaḥ	In the Mahabharata; the popular second half, *dharma hiṁsā tathaiva ca*, is a modern addition
Dharmo rakṣati rakṣitaḥ	Manusmriti 8.15; in the Mahabharata spoken by Draupadi (CE 3.31.7)
The Yaksha's "greatest wonder"	In popular printed editions (Vana Parva 313), not the critical edition

We label sources four ways: Valmiki Ramayana · Mahabharata (critical edition) · Ramcharitmanas of Tulsidas · regional or folk tradition.

KEEP THE THREAD ALIVE

Between gatherings

Week 1	**Verse of the month** Shared on WhatsApp; learn it as a family.
Week 2	**Family small experiment** Try the month's teaching for one week, such as Vidura's rule against delay, and tell us what happened.
Week 3	**Youth-led bhajan jam or heritage walk** Informal, open to all, optional.
Week 4	**A personal invitation** Your lane's volunteer invites you to the next gathering.

The big day: December

A Ramayana–Mahabharata day that every circle prepares for all year: children in costume, a youth quiz, elders' storytelling, recitation, an exhibition of the year's work and the Sanskar Samman for everyone with ten stamps.

EVERYONE HAS A ROLE

Become a sevak

This gurukul belongs to all of us. Choose a role, even for one Sunday.

- Present a topic (2–3 per gathering)
- Lead a learning circle
- Welcome desk and registration
- Seating and elders' care
- Bal Gurukul helper
- Stage, sound and timekeeping
- Quiz master
- Certificates desk
- Photos and WhatsApp updates
- Setting up and clean-up

Ways to give without money

- Lend durries, chairs, a sound system or a projector.
- Open a hall, courtyard or auditorium for one morning.

Seva Kosh. A transparent box at every gathering meets printing and children's materials, about ₹3,500 a month. Giving is voluntary; accounts are read out and posted every quarter.

OUR PROMISE TO FAMILIES

Safe, open and respectful

- Every volunteer signs a short code of conduct.
- No volunteer is ever alone with a child.
- Photos are taken only with written consent, and no child is named or tagged online.
- No shouting, punishment or humiliation, ever.
- One named person handles any concern: [NAME] · [PHONE].
- Every family is welcome, of every community and background.
- No politics: no party symbols, banners or campaigning at any gathering.
- Chairs, a microphone and large print for anyone who needs them.

Mantras for the year

ॐ भूर्भुवः स्वः । तत्सवितुर्वरेण्यं भर्गो देवस्य धीमहि । धियो यो नः प्रचोदयात् ॥

Gayatri, Rigveda 3.62.10: may the divine light inspire our minds.

असतो मा सद्गमय । तमसो मा ज्योतिर्गमय । मृत्योर्मा अमृतं गमय ॥

Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 1.3.28: lead me from untruth to truth, darkness to light, death to immortality.

सं गच्छध्वं सं वदध्वं सं वो मनांसि जानताम् ॥

Rigveda 10.191.2: walk together, speak together, let your minds be in harmony.

सर्वे भवन्तु सुखिनः । सर्वे सन्तु निरामयाः ।
सर्वे भद्राणि पश्यन्तु । मा कश्चिद् दुःखभाग्भवेत् ॥

Traditional closing prayer: may all be happy, may all be free from illness, may all see good, may no one suffer.

MY NOTES

What I learnt this year

Bharat

Rooted in Heritage, Inspired for the Future

Every third Sunday · 9:30 am to 12:30 pm
[VENUE NAME], [LOCALITY]

To join, volunteer or ask: [NAME] · [PHONE]
[SHORT LINK]

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